Dear Editors,

Please consider our manuscript, "When Does Deep Learning Beat Persistence for Groundwater-Level Forecasting? A Reproducible Benchmark and a Persistence-Anchored Residual Model," for publication in Computers & Geosciences.

The manuscript contributes a reproducible, public-data benchmark for daily groundwater-level forecasting built from USGS NWIS records (279 wells, 2000-2024), a strong baseline ladder, and a careful evaluation of when a global residual GRU actually beats persistence. The main findings are:

- Persistence is extremely strong at short horizons (mean NSE 0.97 at one day); a calibrated residual GRU is statistically tied with persistence at 30 days.
- At 90 days, the calibrated model improves median NSE from -0.18 to 0.21 (paired median gain 0.107, 95% CI 0.048-0.225) and mean KGE from 0.46 to 0.52 (95% CI 0.010-0.109); mean NSE is -0.24 vs -0.22 and its interval includes zero because one well dominates the mean.
- A simple per-site ridge baseline has a higher median NSE than the GRU at both horizons, but much heavier mean-error tails. The GRU's independent contribution is fewer severe failures than the raw GRU and ridge, not median supremacy; persistence remains the most conservative tail baseline.
- A fixed global blending weight does not reproduce the per-site gain and is worse than persistence in mean NSE; a per-site validation-fitted weight is essential.
- Missing-input robustness is horizon-dependent: at 30 days, 50% masking pushes mean NSE below persistence; at 90 days, masking does not degrade performance (five repeated mask draws).

We believe this fits Computers & Geosciences because it is a benchmark and software contribution rather than another architecture paper: it provides an open pipeline, purged temporal splits, quality-control code, and an honest negative result about short-horizon deep learning. The code and processed data are available at https://github.com/L-peak/gwbench and archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23749304. Raw observations are public USGS data.

The manuscript is original, is not under consideration elsewhere, and all authors have approved the submission. We declare no competing interests.

Sincerely, Zhaoyang Li Henan Polytechnic University 3286533389@qq.com